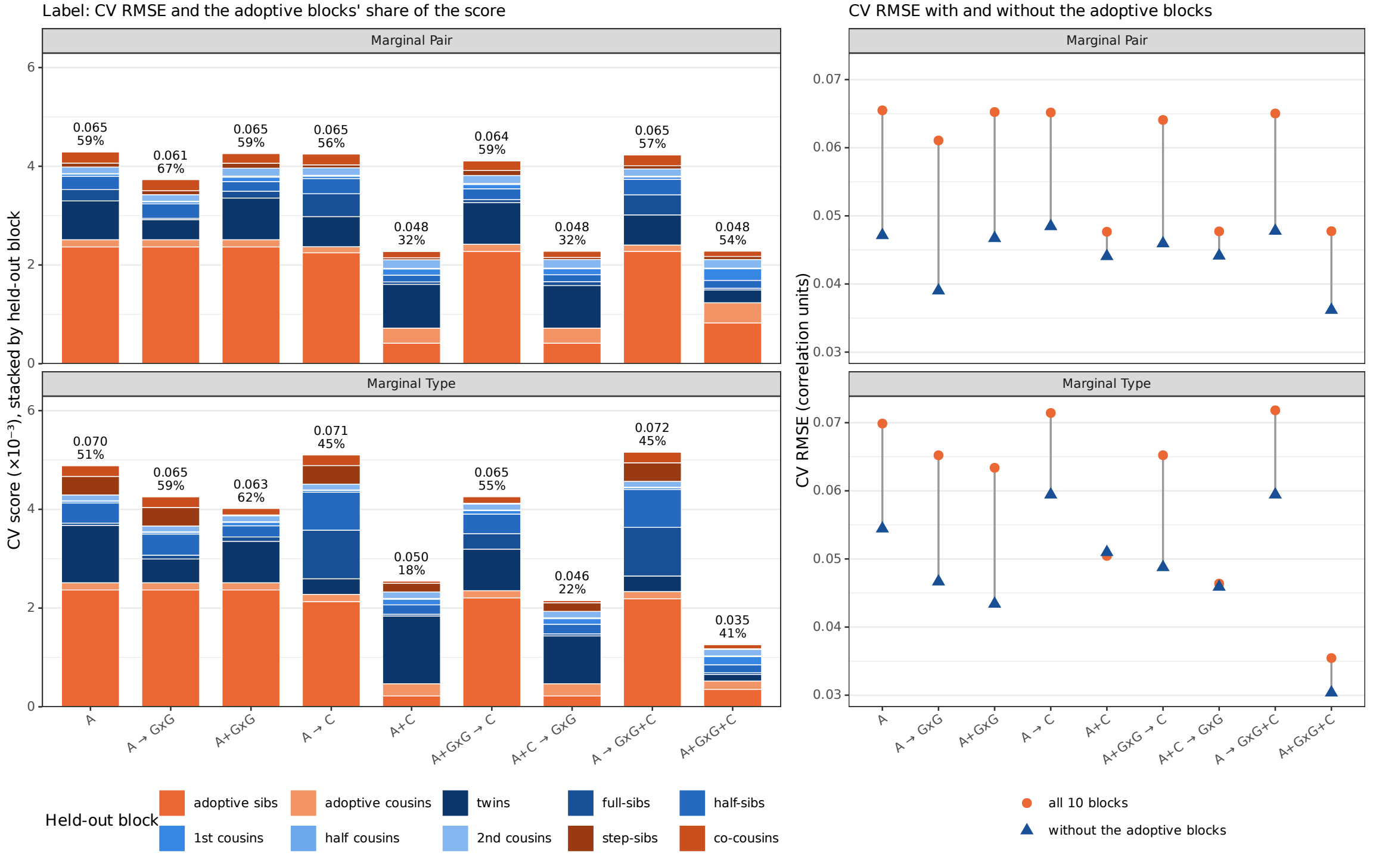Core models: where the cross-validation error comes from